

FAITH FACTOR

TEXT: (Bible character comes onto platform and quotes James chapter one)

INTRO: Over the next 5 weeks we will attempt to cover the entire book of James. This New Testament book is a powerful testimony and challenge to live the Faith life. James is the author of this book and he refers to himself as a ***“servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ.”***

We know him as the half brother of Jesus. [Mark 6:3](#) (NKJV) ***“Is this not the carpenter, the Son of Mary, and brother of James, Joses, Judas, and Simon? And are not His sisters here with us? And they were offended at Him.”*** It is interesting to me that he chooses the identity of ***“servant”*** rather than brother. James is certainly not a person who drops names to impress his friends.

We know that James was a leader in the early church of Jerusalem. [James was an eyewitness of the resurrection.](#) [1 Corinthians 15:7](#) (NKJV) ***“After that He was seen by James, then by all the apostles.”***

The book of James is written to the twelve tribes of Israel. [James 1:1](#) (NKJV) ***“James, a bondservant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ, To the twelve tribes which are scattered abroad:”*** This writing is to churches which consisted mostly of Jewish people who had been scattered among Gentile

nations. So the book of James was a letter to these people and takes on the qualities of Old Testament wisdom literature. It deals with a variety of subjects which describe how to live an upright life. It has much in common with the Sermon on the Mount, taking on subjects like oaths, the tongue, and a challenge to be peacemakers.

I want to entitle this first sermon...

I. VICTORY IN TURMOIL...

In this first chapter, James seems intent on helping us develop a proper attitude toward trials.

James 1:2 (NKJV) “*My brethren, count it all joy when you fall into various trials.*” As Christians we should be diligent to develop a proper attitude toward trials because we will all encounter them. What do the trials and adversities we encounter in life consist of? **Trials could be:**

- Family problems...
- Health complications...
- Emotional difficulties...
- Financial reversals...
- Persecution with regard to faith...

For sure, trials come in all shapes and sizes!

James tells us to “***Consider it all Joy...***” when we encounter such things! How could he make such a demand on people he knew were going to encounter such adversity? **James 1:3 (NKJV)**

“Knowing that the testing of your faith produces patience.” This is not a test to discover whether faith is present but to strengthen our faith! [1 Peter 1:7](#) (NKJV) **“The genuineness of your faith, being much more precious than gold that perishes, though it is tested by fire, may be found to praise, honor, and glory at the revelation of Jesus Christ.”**

The outline of the first chapter of James looks like this: (DO NOT READ AT THIS TIME)

- Greetings to the twelve tribes... Vs. 1-3
- A challenge for the full effect of patience to have its perfect work... Vs.4
- A request for Wisdom... Vs 5
- A challenge to the faith life, and consistency in believing... Vs. 6-8
- A perspective on the rich and the poor... Vs. 9-11
- Loving God in spite of trials... Vs. 12-18
- Description of qualities needed to successfully negotiate trials... Vs. 19-21
- Doers of the Word, not hearers only... Vs. 22-25
- Controlling the tongue... Vs. 26-27
- Serving God... Vs. 27

ILLUSTRATION: CHIPPIE THE

PARAKEET – One second Chippie was safely perched on his roost and the next second he was sucked in, washed up, and blown over... This all occurred when Chippies owner decided to clean his cage with a vacuum cleaner. As she had done many times before, the owner decided to clean Chippies cage without first removing Chippie! She removed the attachment from the end of the hose and stuck it in the cage. The telephone rang, and she turned to pick it up and when she said "hello" she heard this dreadful sound, "ssssopp!" Chippie got sucked in! The bird owner gasped, dropped the telephone, turned off the vacuum, and opened the bag to find Chippie still alive, but stunned and completely covered with soot! In her surprise the owner grabbed Chippie up and raced to the bathroom, turned on the faucet, and held Chippie under the running water! Then, realizing that Chippie was soaked and shivering, she did what any compassionate bird owner would do ... she reached for the hair dryer and blasted the pet with hot air!!! Poor Chippie never knew what hit him! ...A few days later the reporter who wrote the initial story of Chippies accident followed up on the owner to see how Chippie was recovering. When asked about Chippies recovery the owner said, *"Well, Chippie doesn't sing much anymore -- he just sits and stares."*

It's not hard to see why Chippie acts like he does; he was sucked in; washed up; and blown over!

Have you ever had anything to hit you so hard and so suddenly that it left you in a daze or a fog? I

have and quite honestly it's not much fun! But
James say's to ***"Count it all joy..."*** (Some day's I
just want James to keep his thought to himself!
Don't you?

How can we insure that our attitudes will remain
right under pressure? **How can we have victory in
spite of turmoil?** (READ AT THIS TIME)

- **Be quick to hear, slow to speak and impossible to offend...** James 1:19 (NKJV)
"So then, my beloved brethren, let every man be swift to hear, slow to speak, slow to wrath."
- **Remove all known sin...** James 1:21 (NKJV)
"Therefore lay aside all filthiness and overflow of wickedness, and receive with meekness the implanted word, which is able to save your souls."
- **Receive the instruction of the Word of God...** James 1:21 (NKJV) ***"... and receive with meekness the implanted word, which is able to save your souls."***
- **Be a doer of the Word...** James 1:22-25 (NKJV) ***"But be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves. 23 For if anyone is a hearer of the word and not a doer, he is like a man observing his natural face in a mirror;24 for he observes himself, goes away, and immediately forgets what kind of man he was.25 But he who looks into the perfect law of liberty and continues in it, and is not a***

forgetful hearer but a doer of the work, this one will be blessed in what he does.

- **Control the tongue...** James 1:26 (NKJV) ***"If anyone among you thinks he is religious, and does not bridle his tongue but deceives his own heart, this one's religion is useless."***
(Remember, God gave us two ears and one mouth)
- **Become involved in a ministry that God cares about...** James 1:27 (NKJV) ***"Pure and undefiled religion before God and the Father is this: to visit orphans and widows in their trouble, and to keep oneself unspotted from the world."***

James reminds us that even Christians, or should I say, especially Christians, must face trials and temptations. Even though we will encounter difficult situations we do not have to become a victim, we can be a victor!

ILLUSTRATION: An Army Chaplain had a sign on his door that said, *"If you have troubles, come in and tell me all about them. If you don't have troubles, come in and tell me how you do it."*

James 1:2-4 (NKJV) ***"My brethren, count it all joy when you fall into various trials,³ knowing that the testing of your faith produces patience.⁴ But let patience have its perfect work, that you may be perfect and complete, lacking nothing."***

We should consider difficulty “*all joy*” because we know that when tough times come, the end result is going to be perseverance and maturity. Trials are the growing pains of a Christian. Because of this, perseverance and maturity are things that please God. They are essential traits for the Christian life, but the only way to acquire them is through hard times.

This business of being joyful during difficulty is not something that we are to manufacture but a quiet confidence and faith that God is going to produce something in us that will take us to a more beneficial spot in our Christian life. There is more to this than finding joy in what trouble produces; it is enjoying the sweet fruit produced by bitter times.

Someone said, “*The mature Christian life is the sweet fruit of bitter times.*”

Perseverance is the ability to shake off the difficulty and step up when the weight of trials fall upon us! (Story of farmer whose mule fell in a well...)

[James 1:3](#) (NKJV) “**Knowing that the testing of your faith produces patience.**” The Greek term here is *teleion* and it speaks of something that has reached its intended end. Here it refers to the maturity that perseverance produces. [1 Peter 4:12-13](#) (NKJV) “***Beloved, do not think it strange***

concerning the fiery trial which is to try you, as though some strange thing happened to you;¹³ but rejoice to the extent that you partake of Christ's sufferings, that when His glory is revealed, you may also be glad with exceeding joy."

James 1:4 (NKJV) *"But let patience have its perfect work, that you may be perfect and complete, lacking nothing."* The Greek term here speaks of a thing which has all its necessary parts. This implies a process and this Christian life is a process!
(Brinkey Tyler – *"This Christian life is bump, bump; glory, glory; bump, bump..."*)

Warren Wiersbe said, *"The trials of life are not all alike. They are multicolored yarn that the weaver uses to make a beautiful rug. God arranges and mixes the colors and experiences of life and the final product is a beautiful thing for His Glory."*

FAITH FACTOR

TEXT: (Bible character comes onto platform and quotes James chapter two)

INTRO: Last week we began this series on **"Faith Factor"** and we have talked about:

- Victory in Turmoil...

The subject for this week's lesson is **“Awaken Your Faith.”** When I was a young man I could sleep all day, since I am forty plus, if it is daylight, I am awake. The more mature you become the less sleep you require. It is the same in the faith life, the more mature you become in your faith the less likely you will be to fall asleep at the wheel.

The word of God has quite a lot to say about sleep and the danger of lethargy in the Christian life.

Sleep in the Bible is almost always equated with death or spiritual ineptness. [Psalm 17:15](#) (NKJV)

“As for me, I will see Your face in righteousness; I shall be satisfied when I awake in Your likeness.”

[Ephesians 5:14](#) (NKJV) ***“Awake, you who sleep, Arise from the dead, And Christ will give you light.”***

[Romans 13:11](#) (NKJV) ***“And do this, knowing the time, that now it is high time to awake out of sleep; for now our salvation is nearer than when we first believed.”***

Do you know, the average person will spend a third of their life sleeping? What could we accomplish if we could add one third more days to our life? If I could add one third more days to my life, I feel sure I could keep my wife's next husband from enjoying what I have worked so hard for!

[A quick outline of James chapter two](#) looks like this:

- Beware of personal favoritism... Vs. 1-9
- Law versus Grace... Vs. 10-13
- Faith versus works... Vs. 14-26

In verses 1-9 James lets us know in no uncertain terms that it is wrong to show respect to a person because of what they appear to have or do not have. The Word of God has some pretty severe things to say about “*oppressing the poor.*” The punishment for “*oppressing the poor*” will be sure and swift. There is however, a tendency on the part of those who have never been able to acquire much wealth to be prejudiced against those who have experienced a level of prosperity. So this is a two way street.

We must remember that James is writing to the church and he warns against the practice of favoritism based on financial consideration. I know a pastor who spends each afternoon except Wednesday, each week with the top 10% of the givers in his church. James calls upon Christians and church leaders to be impartial.

It takes the “*haves*” and the “*have not’s*” to be a healthy church.

James gives a discourse on law versus grace. [James 2:10-13](#) (NKJV) “**For whoever shall keep the whole law, and yet stumble in one point, he is guilty of all.**” ***11 For He who said, “Do not commit adultery,” also said, “Do not murder.” Now if you do not***

commit adultery, but you do murder, you have become a transgressor of the law.¹² So speak and so do as those who will be judged by the law of liberty.¹³ For judgment is without mercy to the one who has shown no mercy. Mercy triumphs over judgment."

The Law was given to reveal sin; grace came to provide a way of escape from our sinful condition.

The frustrating thing about law is that you are always doing and never done! With law, you can keep 99% of it and fail in one part and the entire thing is offended.

Grace bids us to participate in the forgiveness the blood of Jesus offers. James tells us that under law we get *"judgment without mercy."* This sounds pretty rigid. None of us want a system where we get *"judgment without mercy."*

Let's take a moment to look at Law versus grace:

- The Law appealed to the senses, Grace appeals to the spirit...
- The Law was obscure, Grace is obvious...
- The Law was exclusive, Grace is inclusive...
- The Law was temporary, Grace is eternal...
- The Law makes us feel helpless; Grace reveals that our help comes from the Lord...
- The law can be expressed in two letters, DO; Grace can be expressed in four letters, DONE...
- The Law teaches us to fear, Grace teaches us to hope...
- The Law places us under condemnation, Grace sets the guilty free...

Before he finishes with the subject, James gives us good news. He tells us that under grace ***“mercy rejoices against judgment.”*** In this I have a mental picture of two attorneys facing off in the court room. The battle is ferocious and then the defense presents overwhelming evidence in the favor of his client which blows the prosecution out of the water. The prosecution cannot recover and the person is exonerated. High fives and a party will follow; no doubt about it! James say’s ***“mercy rejoices against judgment.”***

Satan is an accuser of the brethren and he presents his mountain of evidence against each of us only to be upstaged by the fact that the blood of Jesus has covered our sin. (Martin Luther – ***“The Blood of Jesus Christ His Son cleanses me from all sin.”***)

Following this, James takes on the subject of faith versus works or should I say faith and works.

II. AWAKEN YOUR FAITH...

Hebrews 11:1-3 (NKJV) ***“Now faith is the substance of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen.² For by it the elders obtained a good testimony.³ By faith we understand that the worlds were framed by the word of God, so that the things which are seen were not made of things which are visible.”*** Faith is a subject which is not new to any of us, we have heard of faith all of our lives and have heard it preached on a

multitude of times. In the Old Testament there are any number of examples of Gods faithfulness to His people and many examples of people stepping out in faith for God. The word faith is used only two times in the Old Testament:

- A declaration of no faith... Deuteronomy 32:20 (KJV) ***“And he said, I will hide my face from them, I will see what their end shall be: for they are a very froward generation, children in whom is no faith.”***
- A prophetic declaration of a faith which was to come in the future... Habakkuk 2:4 (KJV) ***“... t the just shall live by his faith.”***

In the New Testament faith is mentioned 229 times, 28 times by Jesus. John 20:29 (NKJV) ***“Jesus said to him, **“Thomas, because you have seen Me, you have believed. Blessed are those who have not seen and yet have believed.”*****

When James takes on the subject of faith, he chooses to mix it with works. Most fanatical approaches to faith shy away from works. James takes both subjects on at once. James 2:26 (NKJV) ***“For as the body without the spirit is dead, so faith without works is dead also.”*** In this context, the word faith in the Greek literally means “*persuasion.*” This is “*reliance upon Christ for salvation; constancy in profession; assurance; belief; fidelity.*”

There is a huge difference between the faith that James is speaking of and mind over matter positive thinking therapy. Positive thinking seeks knowledge

to tap the powers of the mind and utilize them to improve the quality of our life. There is certainly nothing wrong with improving on the quality of our life, but the power of positive thinking will eventually fall short of making these things possible.

Biblical faith relates to a God who is able to change our surroundings or change our ability, whichever is needed! [Faith makes:](#)

- [Promises reality...](#)
- [The unseen visible...](#)
- [The incredible credible...](#)
- [The impractical practical...](#)
- [The unattainable attainable...](#)
- [The unworkable workable...](#)
- [The impossible possible...](#)

[Some Biblical examples of faith include:](#)

- [Moses...](#) It took more than a good attitude to get across the Red Sea! It took faith in God followed by obedience (works) to Gods instruction!
- [Gideon...](#) When he faced the Midianites he grew his troops from 32,000 men to 300! In order to keep his troops and himself encouraged he had to do more than thinking happy thoughts!
- [David...](#) It took more than positive thinking to bring down Goliath!
- [Three Hebrew Children...](#) It took more than a great attitude to insulate them against the flames

of an inferno!

- [Daniel...](#) It was more than a positive mind set that enabled Daniel not to be dinner for the lions!

Some of the pseudo-faith stuff we have seen over the years has produced weak Christians who;

- Spend more time believing for the resources to pay their credit card bill than to pay tithes!
- Spend more effort acquiring the faith to believe for a second car than a mission's pledge!
- Spend more mental effort believing for a fishing boat than an outreach effort!

[Hebrews 11:1](#) (NKJV) “Now *faith is the substance of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen.*” I believe it would please God for us to challenge our faith to trust God for the impossible! God wants to use a combination of faith and works to push each of us out of our comfort zone!

Let me shock us all... [Demons have more faith than most Christians!](#) [James 2:18-19](#) (NKJV) “*But someone will say, “You have faith, and I have works.” Show me your faith without your works, and I will show you my faith by my works.19 You believe that there is one God. You do well. Even the demons believe—and tremble!”*

- [Demons know Jesus saves...](#)
- [Demons know the Bible is the Word of God...](#)
- [Demons know who the real healer is...](#)
- [Demons know who the real miracle worker is...](#)

- Demons know who the real source of life is...

Yet, many people who identify themselves as Christians and even entire denominations cannot decide whether they really believe these things! We must awaken our faith!

James uses two Old Testament characters to illustrate the balance between faith and works. [James 2:20-25](#) (NKJV) ***“But do you want to know, O foolish man, that faith without works is dead?21 Was not Abraham our father justified by works when he offered Isaac his son on the altar?22 Do you see that faith was working together with his works, and by works faith was made perfect?23 And the Scripture was fulfilled which says, “Abraham believed God, and it was accounted to him for righteousness.” And he was called the friend of God.24 You see then that a man is justified by works, and not by faith only.25 Likewise, was not Rahab the harlot also justified by works when she received the messengers and sent them out another way?”***

[Look at these two characters:](#)

- [Abraham](#) – Abraham claimed to have faith in God, but when he took Isaac up that mountain and strapped him to the altar of sacrifice he mixed faith with works. As a result he became one of the most prolific Old Testament Bible characters; became righteous; and James declares him to be ***“a friend of God.”***
- [Rahab](#) – Rahab was not a Jewish person; had

not graduated from the Rabbi finishing school; did not have the benefit of theological training; and she probably knew precious little about Jehovah. When the spies came to Jericho she knew enough to ascertain that they were her only hope of escape and she mixed faith with works. In so doing, she spared her own life and that of her family members and earned the right to be in the lineage of Jesus!

The Bible is replete with examples of faith mixed with action:

- Noah built an ark...
- Able offered a sacrifice...
- Sarah had a baby...
- Joshua made 13 trips around the walls of Jericho...
- David killed Goliath...
- Jesus turned the water into wine...
- Jesus fed 5,000 with a little boy's lunch...
- Peter got out of the boat...
- Peter walked out of prison...
- Paul and Silas prayed and sang praises in prison...

CONCLUSION: Notice how James finishes up this chapter. **James 2:26** (NKJV) ***“For as the body without the spirit is dead, so faith without works is dead also.”*** Remember this, faith without works is as useless as a dead body! (Hit the ball and drag Fred)

We must awaken the faith within us which has been allowed to lay dormant! Once we awaken our faith we must mix it with works, and when we do, something good is going to happen!

FAITH FACTOR

TEXT: (Bible character comes onto platform and quotes James chapter three)

INTRO: During this series on “ **Faith Factor**” we have talked about:

- Victory in Turmoil...
- Awaken Your Faith...

Today we are going to look at the power of words in our lives and in particular what kind of effect they have on our faith, both good and bad.

[Proverbs 18:21](#) (NKJV) “*Death and life are in the power of the tongue, And those who love it will eat its fruit.*”

Think about this:

- The Ten Commandments contain 297 words, yet they have served as a moral guide to countless generations...
- The Bill of Rights is stated in 463 words, yet they have guided the judicial and political system of this nation for decades...
- Lincoln’s Gettysburg address is stated in

266 words, yet it has been heralded as one of the most powerful political speeches of modern times...

Some of the most powerful statements in the history of humankind have been stated in a few words. Let me give you an example of this in Scripture. [John 1:1](#) (NKJV) ***“In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.”*** This is quite possibly 17 of the most powerful words in human history. According to one commentary these 17 words are the *“Most compact and pulsating theological statement in all of Scripture.”*

In Dennis Waitley's, *“Empires of the Mind”*, he reported that although *“there are approximately 450,000 words in the English language, about 80% of our conversations use only about 400 words.”* The most common words in the English language are, *“I,” “me,” “my,”* and *“mine.”*

It has been said:

- The six most important words in communications and human relations are, *“I admit that I was wrong”...*
- The five most important words are, *“You did a great job”...*
- The four most important words are, *“What do you think”...*

- The three most important words are, “*May I, please*”...
- The two most important words are, “*Thank you*”...
- The most important word is, “*We*”...
- The least important word is, “*I*”...

Good words bring blessing, bad words bring cursing and strife. **Proverbs 15:1** (NKJV) “*A soft answer turns away wrath, 1 But a harsh word stirs up anger.*”
James 3:9 (NKJV) “*With it we bless our God and Father, and with it we curse men, who have been made in the similitude of God.*”

III. THE AFFECT WORDS HAVE ON FAITH...

A quick look at the third chapter of the book of James reveals:

- A challenge to self control... Vs. 1-2
- The nature of the tongue... Vs. 3-6
- The volatility of the tongue... Vs. 7-8
- The hypocrisy of the tongue... Vs. 9-12
- The fruit of a controlled tongue... Vs. 13
- Characteristics of human wisdom... Vs. 14-16
- Characteristics of Godly wisdom... Vs 17-18

A CHALLENGE TO SELF CONTROL... James 3:1-2 (NKJV) “*My brethren, let not many of you become teachers, knowing that we shall receive a stricter judgment. 2 For we all stumble in many things. If anyone does not stumble in word, he is a perfect man, able also to bridle the whole body.*”

Here James bypasses a host of markers on the road to determining who could qualify to be a mature Christian. He basically say's you can determine a persons spirituality by listening to the words they say! (Guy who joined the Montessori and took an oath of silence: "*Bed's hard; food's cold; I quit...*")

When a person seems to be spiritual but seems to be constantly running their mouth, they are trying to tell us there are other, more serious, issues in their life! James say's the man who can control his tongue ***"Is a perfect man, and able to exercise control over the rest of his body."***

This means there are an awful lot of people in the church who are out of control! If so many people are living their lives out of control is it any wonder there is pandemonium and mayhem in many churches?

THE NATURE OF THE TONGUE... James 3:3-6 (NKJV) ***"Indeed, we put bits in horses' mouths that they may obey us, and we turn their whole body.⁴ Look also at ships: although they are so large and are driven by fierce winds, they are turned by a very small rudder wherever the pilot desires.⁵ Even so the tongue is a little member and boasts great things. See how great a forest a little fire kindles!⁶ And the tongue is a fire, a world of iniquity. The tongue is so set among our members that it defiles the whole body, and sets on fire the course of nature; and it is set on fire by hell."***

James tells us, **the nature of the tongue is all about**

who is in control. The control of the tongue can be far reaching; it can determine the potential of a person's life. If we are not in control of our tongue it is a fact that the tongue can keep us back from God's purpose in our life. Some people go from a ten to a two in six sentences or less! If we can control our tongue, we can reach the destiny God has in mind for us.

James uses the following things to describe the kind of control our tongue is capable of exerting over our lives:

- Bits that guide a horse... Vs. 3
- Rudders which guide a ship... Vs. 4
- Little fires that kindle greater fires... Vs. 5

James 3:6 (NKJV) ***"And the tongue is a fire, a world of iniquity. The tongue is so set among our members that it defiles the whole body, and sets on fire the course of nature; and it is set on fire by hell."***

THE VOLATILITY OF THE TONGUE... James 3:7-8 (NKJV) ***"For every kind of beast and bird, of reptile and creature of the sea, is tamed and has been tamed by mankind.⁸ But no man can tame the tongue. It is an unruly evil, full of deadly poison."***

Let's look at how volatile the tongue really is. James says that man has conquered the art of taming the nature of wild animals, yet the tongue seems to evade being conquered by a large part of the population.

James makes the following observations with regard to the volatility of the tongue:

- No man can tame it... It takes God to do this!

- **It is an unruly, evil influence...** It has destroyed families, governments, corporations, financial empires, and many churches!
- **It is full of deadly poison...** How many people do you estimate have been poisoned by the casual, meaningless gossip of people who call themselves Christians?

THE HYPOCRISY OF THE TONGUE... James 3:9-12 (NKJV) ***“With it we bless our God and Father, and with it we curse men, who have been made in the similitude of God.10 Out of the same mouth proceed blessing and cursing. My brethren, these things ought not to be so.11 Does a spring send forth fresh water and bitter from the same opening? 12 Can a fig tree, my brethren, bear olives, or a grapevine bear figs? Thus no spring yields both salt water and fresh.”***

James say's a person can bless God with the tongue one minute and clean his neighbors clock the next. Blessing and cursing are capable of originating from the same mouth because of the tongue. How hypocritical! James said, ***“These things ought not to be.”***

He say's everything else on earth bears fruit after its kind but the tongue seems to be a vine of many fruits. While it seems a person is talking out both sides of their mouth, the truth is, when a person speaks, they are showing an accurate picture of their inner being!

If we look at what the Bible has to say about the

tongue we will quickly discover just how hypocritical the tongue can be:

- Vipers tongue... Job 20:16
- Flattering tongue... Psalms 5:9
- Proud tongue... Psalms 12:3
- Lying tongue... Psalms 109:2
- Deceitful tongue... Psalms 120:2
- False tongue... Psalms 120:3
- Forward tongue... Proverbs 10:31
- Wholesome tongue... Proverbs 15:4
- Healthy tongue... Proverbs 12:18
- Naughty tongue... Proverbs 17:4
- Perverse tongue... Proverbs 17:20
- Soft tongue... Proverbs 25:15
- Stammering tongue... Isaiah 28:11, 33:19
- Backbiting tongue... Proverbs 25:23

THE FRUIT OF A CONTROLLED TONGUE...

James 3:13 (NKJV) ***“Who is wise and understanding among you? Let him show by good conduct that his works are done in the meekness of wisdom.”***

For sure the tongue is deceitful and hypocritical; the person who avoids its pitfalls will be the person whose life is lived in total submission to God. Controlling the tongue allows the believer to be self-controlled. In the Greek the word ***“conversation”*** means conduct or behavior. This pretty much takes in every area of our lives, both private and public.

James says the person who has learned to control the tongue is both ***“wise”*** and ***“filled with knowledge.”*** If

a person is “*wise*” and “*filled with knowledge*” his life will be blessed of the Lord and blessed by men.

CHARACTERISTICS OF HUMAN WISDOM...

James 3:14-16 (NKJV) “*But if you have bitter envy and self-seeking in your hearts, do not boast and lie against the truth.15 This wisdom does not descend from above, but is earthly, sensual, demonic.16 For where envy and self-seeking exist, confusion and every evil thing are there.*”

The characteristics of human wisdom are as follows:

- **Bitter envying...** The Greek word here is Zeloi and manifests itself through jealousy and attempting to excel at the expense of others; seeking to surpass and outdo others; and an uncurbed rivalry spirit in religion, business, society and other fields of endeavor.
- **Strife in the heart...** This is a person who is conflicted within themselves. This oftentimes results in temper tantrums and unexpected outbursts.
- **Glory in profession...** This causes a person to be a braggart often exaggerating to appear to be more successful than they are.
- **Earthly...** This kind of person lives for the here and now, not considering eternity. This manifests itself through materialism.
- **Sensual...** This kind of person lives to satisfy the animal appetites.
- **Devilish...** The person who operates in such a spirit is operating in an evil spirit. Their actions

are born out of demonic ideas.

- **Confused and conflicted...** The person who walks in this kind of wisdom is constantly causing confusion in all of their relationships.
- **Every evil work...** When a person allows strife to control their life they also open themselves up to every evil work!

As a believer, we want to guard against such things being allowed to find a place in our lives.

CHARACTERISTICS OF GODLY WISDOM...

James 3:17-18 (NKJV) ***“But the wisdom that is from above is first pure, then peaceable, gentle, willing to yield, full of mercy and good fruits, without partiality and without hypocrisy.18 Now the fruit of righteousness is sown in peace by those who make peace.”***

Godly wisdom in the life of the believer looks like this:

- **Pure...** This kind of wisdom causes the believer to operate in a way that is chaste, holy and clean. Matthew 5:8 (NKJV) ***“Blessed are the pure in heart, For they shall see God.”***
- **Peaceable...** This does not mean a believer will never have conflicts. It means that a believer who is operating in Godly wisdom is easy to make peace with. Matthew 5:9 (NKJV) ***“Blessed are the peacemakers, For they shall be called sons of God.”*** Gentle... This means the believer will be meek (not weak), modest

and kind. Matthew 5:5 (NKJV) ***“Blessed are the meek, For they shall inherit the earth.”***

- **Easily entreated...** This means the believer will not be stubborn or obstinate, but easy to deal with in all situations.
- **Full of mercy...** This means the believer will always be quick to forgive and constantly performing random acts of kindness. Matthew 5:7 (NKJV) ***“Blessed are the merciful, For they shall obtain mercy.”***
- **Full of good fruit...** This means the believer will always allow the fruit of the spirit to be on display in their lives. (Gal. 5:22-23) Galatians 5:22-23 (NKJV) ***“But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, longsuffering, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control. Against such there is no law.”***
- **Without partiality...** This means the believer who is operating in Godly wisdom will not allow prejudice to be a part of their thought process.
- **Without hypocrisy...** This means a believer’s private persona and public persona will be one and the same.

CONCLUSION: As you can see, words have power and they shape and define our lives. Words reveal the faith we have in God, others, and ourselves. If the believer has the power to control his tongue he has a wonderful opportunity to live the faith life and please God. If we cannot control our tongue, our words will

destroy our faith and that of others, and will keep us from pleasing God.

FAITH FACTOR

TEXT: (Bible character comes onto platform and quotes James chapter Four)

INTRO: During this series on “ **Faith Factor**” we have talked about:

- Victory in Turmoil...
- Awaken Your Faith...
- The Affect Our Words Have on Faith...

Today I want us to study chapter four entitling it...

IV. THE WAR AGAINST FAITH COMES FROM WITHIN...

A quick look at the outline of James chapter four looks like this: (DO NOT READ AT THIS TIME)

- The source of high level conflict... Vs. 1
- Reasons for unanswered prayer... Vs. 2-3
- The effect of worldliness on faith... Vs. 4-6
- Conditions of answered prayer... Vs. 7-10
- A warning against judging others... Vs. 11-12
- A warning against self-confidence... Vs. 13-16
- A warning against procrastination... Vs. 17

THE SOURCE OF HIGH LEVEL CONFLICT...

During this time period the Jews of Judea were in a tremendous conflict with the Romans. They had led several insurrections against the Romans under the pretense of defending their religious ideology.

However, the real problem was that the Jews were divided into several factions and they were fighting against and massacring one another. The division from within caused the Jews to be impotent against their real enemies. It is against this backdrop that James writes, [James 4:1](#) (NKJV) ***“Where do wars and fights come from among you? Do they not come from your desires for pleasure that war in your members?”***

All of us attempt to live in a state of preparedness when it comes to external conflicts but most of us seem to struggle when we are faced with conflict from within. This is true of governments, individuals, churches and organizations.

The most difficult problem a church will grapple with is an uprising from within. When a force from the outside threatens to damage the church, its leaders and laity will normally close ranks and defeat the threat. However, [churches and organizations implode when inner conflict is not properly dealt with](#). (Look at Enron...)

[In the life of the believer, the enemy who poses the greatest threat is not an external conflict, but an inward conflict](#). An inward conflict is a tremendous assault against the faith of the believer. Our arch

enemy is not omniscient but his influence is in our nature, it is encoded in our flesh.

REASONS FOR UNANSWERED PRAYER...

James 4:2-3 (NKJV) ***"You lust and do not have. You murder and covet and cannot obtain. You fight and war. Yet you do not have because you do not ask.³ You ask and do not receive, because you ask amiss, that you may spend it on your pleasures."*** James is one of those rare authors who get right down to it and just say's it like it is. You do not need to write excessive words when you have this style of speaking. (A staff member once told a staff member from another church, *"If you hear my pastor beating around the bush he is trying to loosen it up so he can extricate it."*)

I guess I like James because of his direct demeanor. In just two verses he gives us [seven reasons for unanswered prayer](#):

- [Lust...](#) ***"You lust and do not have."***
- [Murder...](#) ***"You murder... and cannot obtain."***
- [Covetousness...](#) ***"You... covet and cannot obtain."***
- [Strife...](#) ***"You fight and war."***
- [Failure to ask...](#) ***"You do not have because you do not ask."***

- **Wrong motives...** *“You ask and do not receive, because you ask amiss... that you may spend it on your pleasures.”*
- **Materialism...** *“You ask and do not receive..., that you may spend it on your pleasures.”*

Again, the reasons for our prayers not being answered are all internal. The war against our faith is from within.

THE EFFECT OF WORLDLINESS ON FAITH...

Make no mistake about it; worldliness has a profound negative impact on the life of the believer. James draws this conclusion and **points out the following things:**

- **Friendship with the world identifies the individual as the enemy of God...** James 4:4 (KJV) *“Ye adulterers and adulteresses, know ye not that the friendship of the world is enmity with God? whosoever therefore will be a friend of the world is the enemy of God.”* This is not friendships with people in the world but with this world's system! A friendship comes complete with a level of comfort and intimacy.
- **The human spirit has a natural bent toward lust and envy...** James 4:5 (KJV) *“Do ye think that the scripture saith in vain, The spirit that dwelleth in us lusteth to envy?”* Every one of us is in constant need of bringing our human spirits under the authority of the Holy Spirit. The reason for this is because this carnal flesh

has an appetite which can only be restricted by the power of the Holy Spirit.

- **God resists the proud...** James 4:6 (KJV) ***“But he giveth more grace. Wherefore he saith, God resisteth the proud, but giveth grace unto the humble.”*** One of the most direct and pointed Scriptures in the Bible makes a statement concerning this subject. Proverbs 6:16-19 (KJV) ***“These six things doth the LORD hate: yea, seven are an abomination unto him: 17 A proud look, a lying tongue, and hands that shed innocent blood, 18 An heart that deviseth wicked imaginations, feet that be swift in running to mischief, 19 A false witness that speaketh lies, and he that soweth discord among brethren.”***

The battle against worldliness has to do with our passions which are an inward problem. The battle against our faith is primarily inward rather than outward.

CONDITIONS OF ANSWERED PRAYER...

James 4:7-10 (NKJV) ***“Therefore submit to God. Resist the devil and he will flee from you.8 Draw near to God and he will flee from you. Cleanse your hands, you sinners; and purify your hearts, you double-minded.9 Lament and mourn and weep! Let your laughter be turned to mourning and your joy to gloom.10 Humble yourselves in the sight of the Lord, and He will lift you up.”***

James points out six things which are requirements for the believer to place himself in a position to have his prayers answered:

- **Submit to God...** Submission is an act of laying aside ones own ideas in order to take on the ideas of another. There are two times to submit; when we feel like it, and when we do not feel like it. When the disciples of John the Baptist were attempting to deify him, he made the following statement concerning the relationship between him and Jesus. [John 3:30](#) (NKJV) ***“He must increase, but I must decrease.”*** Because of human nature, this is easier to say than to do.
- **Resist the devil...** One would think that if they submit to God that would be all that is needed but we must take it a step further to actively opposing the enemy and his agenda. This is a call to action; a challenge to activism; a push to engage the enemy on his territory. If we are going to get our prayers answered we must recover from the philosophy of meeting behind our stained glass windows, holding hands, and singing cum-by-yah-my-Lord. We must storm the strongholds of hell! If we do this, look at the promise... ***“He will flee from you!”***
- **Draw nigh to God...** Notice, this is an action which the believer must initiate... Once the believer makes a move toward the Lord, there is a promise which follows his action... ***“He will flee from you.”***
- **Cleanse your hands you sinners...** James is

writing to Christians so they are not actually sinners but he is pointing to the fact that all of us have a bent toward being led away by the appetites of the flesh. The command to ***“cleanse our hands”*** carries with it the reference to what each of us does many times each day, wash our hands. We are continually washing our hands to rid ourselves of the germs acquired from the dirty world we live in. In a spiritual sense, we are to be constantly washing the world from our flesh.

- **Purify your hearts...** This is different from cleansing our hands. One has to do with the flesh; the other has to do with the inner man which deals with our motives. If we are driven by wrong motives we will be ***“double minded”*** giving up on our ideals when the going gets tough. When we are motivated by the purposes of God, we develop a constancy which allows us to remain committed through the best of times and the worst of times.
- **Be afflicted and mourn...** This is James’ way of telling the people to be quick to repent. In James’ culture when a person was engaged in a true act of repentance they would lie on the ground and roll themselves in the dust. He continues to emphasize his point by saying, ***“Let your laughter be turned to mourning, and your joy to heaviness. Humble yourselves in the sight of the Lord.”*** Obeying James’ command here would not allow for flippant admissions of

wrongdoing. Notice the promise if the aforementioned command is followed, ***“He shall lift you up!”*** This literally means *“He will answer your prayers.”*

I suppose all of us would like to know that our prayers are going to be answered. James tells us that if we will follow these six simple guidelines we can have confidence that the Lord will hear and answer our prayers. In other words, if we can find a way to align the spirit (inward man) with the priorities and purposes of God, our faith will soar, if not, our faith will falter. This is an inward conflict which works against our faith walk.

A WARNING AGAINST JUDGING OTHERS...

James 4:11-12 (NKJV) ***“Do not speak evil of one another, brethren. He who speaks evil of a brother and judges his brother, speaks evil of the law and judges the law. But if you judge the law, you are not a doer of the law but a judge.12 There is one Lawgiver, who is able to save and to destroy. Who are you to judge another?”*** The backdrop from which James writes these verses is that the Jews had broken into multiple factions and were backbiting and slandering one another.

The Greek word for judge here is “katalaleo” which means to:

- Speak against...
- Backbite...

- Rail at...
- Slander...

Most of us would vehemently deny that we judge others; however, James plainly tells us that when we speak negatively of others we have moved in the arena of judging others. Some people would determine that if what they are saying about others is true they would not be sitting in judgment. If we pass negative information about other people we assume the position of judge.

James say's "***There is one law giver***" or judge, and when we sit in judgment of others we have in effect taken God's place through a hostile takeover! We must remember, every time we judge another believer; we beat God to the bench to pre-judge the individual and when we do that, God will judge us before He judges the other individual! (My experience with a church leader trying to push me into a premature decision)

The very act of a hostile takeover of the judicial system of God is a battle that rages within all of us, but to give into such desires is an overt action against our faith.

A WARNING AGAINST SELF-CONFIDENCE...

James 4:13-16 (NKJV) *"Come now, you who say, "Today or tomorrow we will go to such and such a city, spend a year there, buy and sell, and make a profit";¹⁴ whereas you do not know what will happen tomorrow. For what is your life? It is even a vapor*

that appears for a little time and then vanishes away.¹⁵ Instead you ought to say, "If the Lord wills, we shall live and do this or that."¹⁶ But now you boast in your arrogance. All such boasting is evil."

The cultural context here is that some of the Jews made their living traveling from city to city selling their wares in the bazaars which were a primary place of commerce. Obviously these Jews were continually bragging about what bazaar they were going to be a part of and how much money they would make. The fact that they were entrepreneurs was not the problem; the problem was that they did not consider the will of God as important as their natural ability to make money.

For any believer to operate in an attitude which says "*I can do this in my own ability,*" is a outward manifestation of an inward problem. The inward problem is one of self confidence rather than a reliance on God which says "*I will do this or that If it is God's will.*" The act of giving in to self-confidence initiates a process of the erosion of faith in God.

A WARNING AGAINST PROCRASTINATION...

James 4:17 (NKJV) *"Therefore, to him who knows to do good and does not do it, to him it is sin."*

Knowing to do a good deed and not performing is the act of procrastination. In this context **procrastination is sin and sin is the enemy of faith.**

Someone said **"Never do today, what you can put off until tomorrow."**

James takes a shot at procrastination, by letting us know that we are not only to be people of faith but to place legs on our faith by doing good works.

The act of procrastination stems from an inward decision to wait. When I was a young boy my dad would tell me to do something and on very rare occasions I would say, “*Wait just a minute,*” my dad would response “*wait (weight) is what broke the bridge down.*”

CONCLUSION:

As you can see, almost everything James talks about in chapter four points to an inward battle. This battle is an assault on our faith. If we do not win the battle against inward forces we will be hopeless to win external battles. God is able to give us the grace and stamina to size up the enemy and employ the power necessary to dismantle the malignant forces which would come against our faith.

FAITH FACTOR

TEXT: (Bible character comes onto platform and quotes James chapter Five)

INTRO: During this series on “ **Faith Factor**” we have talked about:

- Victory in Turmoil...
- Awaken Your Faith...

- The Affect Our Words Have on Faith...
- The War Against Faith Comes From Within...

Today I want us to study chapter five entitling it...

V. BASIC FAITH 101...

A quick look at James chapter five reveals the following: (DO NOT READ AT THIS TIME)

- The vanity of trusting in riches... Vs. 1-6
- The reward of patient faith... Vs. 7-8
- Failure to forgive results in the loss of faith... Vs. 9
- Suffering is not a sign of anemic faith... Vs. 10-11
- An admonition not to place confidence in anything other than God... Vs. 12
- Faith, the cure for afflictions and sickness... Vs. 13-16
- Prayer mixed with faith always results in miracles... Vs. 17-18
- Faith, the answer to sin and failure... Vs. 19-20

THE VANITY OF TRUSTING IN RICHES...

James 5:1-6 (NKJV) ***“Come now, you rich, weep and howl for your miseries that are coming upon you!² Your riches are corrupted, and your garments are moth-eaten.³ Your gold and silver are corroded, and their corrosion will be a witness against you and will eat your flesh like fire. You have heaped up treasure in the last days.⁴ Indeed the wages of the laborers who mowed your fields, which you kept back by***

fraud, cry out; and the cries of the reapers have reached the ears of the Lord of Sabaoth.⁵ *You have lived on the earth in pleasure and luxury; you have fattened your hearts as in a day of slaughter.*⁶ *You have condemned, you have murdered the just; he does not resist you.”*

Allow me to say this concerning material things:

- **God is not against prosperity!** In fact, He desires it for His people! **3 John 2** (NKJV) *“Beloved, I pray that you may prosper in all things and be in health, just as your soul prospers.”*
- **Riches in and of themselves are not evil it is the love of riches which corrupt the spirit of man!**
Paul warns his son Timothy about this very danger. **1 Timothy 6:9-10** (NKJV) *“But those who desire to be rich fall into temptation and a snare, and into many foolish and harmful lusts which drown men in destruction and perdition.¹⁰ For the love of money is a root of all kinds of evil, for which some have strayed from the faith in their greediness, and pierced themselves through with many sorrows.”* Let me remind you that you can love money without having it, and you can have it without loving it.
- **God will only bless you with what He can trust you with!** **3 John 2** (NKJV) *“Beloved, I pray that you may prosper in all things and be in health, just as your soul prospers.”*
- **Material possessions are entrusted to us to sustain our families in this world!** **Genesis 3:19**

(NKJV) *“In the sweat of your face you shall eat bread Till you return to the ground...” 1 Timothy 5:8-9 (NKJV) “But if anyone does not provide for his own, and especially for those of his household, he has denied the faith and is worse than an unbeliever.” This provision is both physical and spiritual; present and future.*

- *If God can get it through you He will get it to you!* A good rule of thumb: 10% tithe; 10% savings; 33% for taxes; the rest for living expenses and offerings. (Someone said, “Don’t sow your eating seed, and don’t eat your sowing seed.”)

James lets us know that any attempt to hoard riches at the expense of others will be severely dealt with by the Lord.

One of the basic principles of Faith 101 is to remember that your faith cannot necessarily be measured by your financial portfolio!

THE REWARD OF PATIENT FAITH...

James 5:7-8 (NKJV) “Therefore be patient, brethren, until the coming of the Lord. See how the farmer waits for the precious fruit of the earth, waiting patiently for it until it receives the early and latter rain.⁸ You also be patient. Establish your hearts, for the coming of the Lord is at hand.”

I love the way James challenges his readers to patiently wait for the end result of their faith. He uses

the example of a farmer patiently awaiting harvest. Any good farmer knows that even though his vision is for the harvest, his time between seed time and harvest will be spent doing all the things to affect the greatest return possible, on the day of harvest.

The process of farming looks like this; **SEED + T-I-M-E = HARVEST...** Hebrews 10:36 (NKJV) ***“For you have need of endurance, so that after you have done the will of God, you may receive the promise:”***

Faith 101 teaches us, the person who cannot acquire patience will never know the joy of receiving all the things faith is capable of producing.

FAILURE TO FORGIVE, RESULTS IN THE LOSS OF FAITH...

James 5:9 (NKJV) ***“Do not grumble against one another, brethren, lest you be condemned. Behold, the Judge is standing at the door!”***

Failure to forgive is one of the most disabling things a Christian can do. **The presence of un-forgiveness in ones life separates the believer from God.** Matthew 6:15 (NKJV) ***“But if you do not forgive men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses.”***

There can be no faith in a life of estrangement from God. If a believer is operating in bitterness and un-forgiveness they will flunk out of faith 101!

SUFFERING IS NOT A SIGN OF ANEMIC FAITH...

James 5:10-11 (NKJV) “*My brethren, take the prophets, who spoke in the name of the Lord, as an example of suffering and patience.11 Indeed we count them blessed who endure. You have heard of the perseverance of Job and seen the end intended by the Lord—that the Lord is very compassionate and merciful.*” The doctrine that says, if you have faith you will never have problems is about as far off as any doctrine could ever be.

In the book of James, the author states and restates the fact that [faith is proven through testing](#). James 1:2-4 (NKJV) “*My brethren, count it all joy when you fall into various trials,3 knowing that the testing of your faith produces patience,4 But let patience have its perfect work, that you may be perfect and complete, lacking nothing.*”

Hebrews 10:38 (NKJV) “*Now the just shall live by faith; But if anyone draws back, My soul has no pleasure in him.*” Hebrews 11:39-40 (NKJV) “*And all these, having obtained a good testimony through faith, did not receive the promise,40 God having provided something better for us, that they should not be made perfect apart from us.”*

One of the first things you learn in Faith 101 is that suffering will come to those who live the faith life, and trouble is to the faith walker, as the wind beneath the wings of an eagle.

[AN ADMONITION NOT TO PLACE CONFIDENCE IN ANYTHING OTHER THAN GOD...](#)

James 5:12 (NKJV) “*But above all, my brethren, do*

not swear, either by heaven or by earth or with any other oath. But let your “Yes,” be “Yes,” and your “No,” “No,” lest you fall into judgment.” Jews and Arabs alike were accustomed to sealing everything they said with an oath. The oaths they made were based on just about everything imaginable. In that culture if you were to make a promise you would seal it with something like “*in the name of Yahweh,*” only they were using all kinds of other things with which to seal their promise. The promise was no better than the oath with which it was sealed. If they sealed a promise with an oath then recanted on their promise they would bring a reproach on the thing with which it was sealed.

It was in this context that Paul says the following to the Philippian Christians: [Philippians 4:19](#) (NKJV) ***“And my God shall supply all your need according to His riches in glory by Christ Jesus.”*** Listen to what the writer of Hebrews has to say on the subject. [Hebrews 6:13-17](#) (NKJV) ***“For when God made a promise to Abraham, because He could swear by no one greater, He swore by Himself,*¹⁴ *saying, “Surely blessing I will bless you, and multiplying I will multiply you.”*¹⁵ *And so, after he had patiently endured, he obtained the promise.*¹⁶ ***For men indeed swear by the greater, and an oath for confirmation is for them an end of all dispute.***¹⁷ ***Thus God, determining to show more abundantly to the heirs of promise the immutability of His counsel, confirmed it by an oath,”*****

One of the lessons of Faith 101 is that [everything we do must be within the will of God, and that everything](#)

is by Him and through Him. We are not living this faith life in our own strength but through His strength.

FAITH, THE CURE FOR AFFLICTIONS AND SICKNESSES...

James 5:13-16 (NKJV) ***"Is any among you afflicted? let him pray. Is any merry? let him sing psalms. 14 Is any sick among you?"*** (Child who asked his father, ***"What is a sickamungus?"***) ***let him call for the elders of the church; and let them pray over him, anointing him with oil in the name of the Lord: 15 And the prayer of faith shall save the sick, and the Lord shall raise him up; and if he have committed sins, they shall be forgiven him. 16 Confess your faults one to another, and pray one for another, that ye may be healed. The effectual fervent prayer of a righteous man availeth much."***

There is a big difference between ***"Affliction"*** and ***"Sickness,"*** and let us also notice that the way we are to deal with them is very different as well.

"Affliction" is simply problems of a non physical nature. When the believer encounters such a circumstance he is to pray for himself. The reason for this is because we are Gods children and He desires to deal with us on a person to person basis. We all love to have someone speak a word over us, but a word of Prophecy should never be initial direction but confirmation of direction. When I encounter problems in my Christian life and my initial response is to seek someone to speak a word over me, this action offends the Father. If either of my children were grappling

with a difficulty and they came to one of you to talk to me to get a word of direction I would be offended and it would point out that something is deficient in the relationship between my child and I.

When we are “*sick*” we are to seek out the help of the elders of the church. Listen to the promise for those who follow this Biblical mandate. *“And the prayer of faith shall save the sick, and the Lord shall raise him up; and if he have committed sins, they shall be forgiven him.”*

Verse 16 is a largely overlooked passage of Scripture. *“Confess your faults one to another, and pray one for another, that ye may be healed..”* The reason for confessing our faults to one another is not for forgiveness but for accountability.

Faith 101 teaches us:

- If we are encountering difficulty we have Gods attention... Call Him up!
- When we are sick we are to call the elders of the church... God is still in the healing business!
- The elders are to anoint us with oil in the name of the Lord... The prayer of faith will heal the sick!
- We need human accountability... When we establish this we can expect to be delivered!

Listen to the latter part of verse 16, ***[“The effectual fervent prayer of a righteous man availeth much.”](#)***

This verse paraphrased would be ***“The producing, valid, intensely earnest prayer of a righteous person will get the job done.”***

PRAYER MIXED WITH FAITH ALWAYS RESULTS IN MIRACLES...

James 5:17-18 (NKJV) ***“Elijah was a man with a nature like ours, and he prayed earnestly that it would not rain; and it did not rain on the land for three years and six months.18 And he prayed again, and the heaven gave rain, and the earth produced its fruit.”*** I think it very interesting the way James chooses to tackle the issue of prayer.

He chooses to cite the example of the Old Testament prophet Elijah. He states very simply that ***“Elijah prayed that it would not rain, and it rained not for the space of three years and six months.”*** I am sure Elijah’s prayers were mixed with faith to get such extreme results.

A lesson we learn in Faith 101 is that **[prayer mixed with faith moves the hand of the Lord.](#)**

He simply says ***“And he prayed again and the heavens gave forth the rain, and the earth produced its fruit.”*** I am quite sure that Elijah did not wait three and one half years to pray again, but once God shut the water faucet off, Elijah did not pray for rain for three and one half years. The very next time he prayed he got results!

James says that Elijah was not a special case, he is just

like us. If God will respond to Elijah's prayers He will surely respond to ours!

FAITH, THE ANSWER TO SIN AND FAILURE...

James 5:19-20 (NKJV) ***"Brethren, if anyone among you wanders from the truth, and someone turns him back, let him know that he who turns a sinner from the error of his way will save a soul from death and cover a multitude of sins."***

Everyone is susceptible to sin and failure. James lets us know that when this occurs, **faith in God and His Word will result in the guilty being forgiven.**

The greatest miracle is when a sin is forgiven. The greatest lesson of Faith 101 is that faith is the answer to all sin and failure.

CONCLUSION:

James is full of good lessons on the following subjects:

- Victory in Turmoil...
- Awaken Your Faith...
- The Effect Our Words Have on Faith...
- The War Against Faith Comes From Within...
- Basic Faith 101...

If we will live by the lessons of faith which we have learned over the past five weeks we will

please God, win many victories, and give the devil
a nervous break-down!

